

52.1 The Battle of Evesham

The Battle of Evesham brought an end both to the Second Barons' War against the crown and to the power of Henry III. It would be two years before final terms of peace were signed, and eight before Henry III's reign finally ended. But from the moment of victory at Evesham, Edward—twenty-six years old, six foot two and towering over his peers, hardened by constant service in his father's army—was the real ruler of England.

MEANWHILE, the Sicilian match that had lit the English powderkeg was burning merrily away in new directions.

Since Henry was clearly not going to get Sicily out of Manfred's hands, Pope Urban IV offered the crown to Louis IX instead. Louis declined, on principle; he did not wish to be the usurper of young Conradin's rights. But Urban IV found a more willing candidate in Louis's younger brother, Charles of Anjou: aged forty, constantly in motion, a veteran of the failed Damietta Crusade, impatient with Louis's scruples and ambitious for himself. He agreed at once—over Louis's objections—to both take the crown and conquer the country. And, like Henry III nearly a decade earlier, he accepted a truly awful set of conditions in exchange for the meaningless title. He agreed to give up all power over the clergymen in Sicily, to claim no other title in Italy, to pay off the English debt to Rome, and to hand over an enormous yearly tribute to the pope. In exchange, he got the name of king—and the pope's promise to give anyone who fought against Manfred the rewards of crusade.[15]

By the time Charles arrived in Sicily, Urban IV too was dead (the